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Source: *U.S. Catholic Historian*, Spring, 1999, Vol. 17, No. 2, French Connections (Spring, 1999), pp. 91-105

Published by: Catholic University of America Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/25154671>

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# Reflections On Yves Congar and Theology in the United States

Thomas F. O'Meara, O.P.

**W**hat have been the presence, the impact, the legacy of Yves Congar in the United States? We can hope that the future will see a number of scholarly studies responding to that question.<sup>1</sup> The following pages give only impressions and intimations; partly they are impressions of someone living through some of the times of Congar's life. They are impressions of a theologian in ecclesiology who is not a historian of the American church but was at times a witness to the great theologian at work. As a Dominican novice I viewed Congar as a distant figure among French Dominicans in wool habits and tonsures, but I was told by my superiors that he was involved in questionable enterprises; during my years as a theology student in Germany I saw Congar on the streets of Rome giving out material to the bishops attending Vatican II; fifteen years later I visited him occasionally at S. Jacques. Others see in their own way the work and destiny of the theologian whose writings — some laborious in historical research, some original in theology — contributed so much to the great themes of Vatican II. Richard McBrien writes: "By any account, Yves Congar is the most distinguished ecclesiologist of this century and perhaps of the entire post-Tridentine era. No modern theologian's spirit was accorded fuller play in the documents of Vatican II than Congar's."<sup>2</sup>

## I. Absent from the American Church

When one looks at American theological journals in the 1950s and 1960s Yves Congar is little present. A cursory survey indicates no articles in several leading American theological journals on Yves Congar between 1950 and 1970 and only a few reviews.<sup>3</sup> William R. O'Connor of New York in reviewing *Lay People in the Church* in 1958 praised the importance of the topic and noticed the theological neglect of the laity over the centuries. He appreciated the introduction of the laity into the life (if not the structure) of the church, and yet he treated Congar's important themes too often as ways of continuing to set apart

and limit the laity rather than as reintroductions of the baptized into the active church. The book is compared to and critiqued by *Humani generis* and *Mystici corporis* and the review blandly and incorrectly ends: "In our opinion Father Congar's book will raise more questions than it answers. Perhaps this is a good thing. Time alone will tell."<sup>4</sup>

In 1962, prior to the first session of the Ecumenical Council Vatican II, the then well-known Roman and curial theologian, Dino Staffa, wrote an essay on the unity of faith. He named three constitutive factors bestowing church unity: Thomism, the juridical structure concretized in the *Codex Juris Canonici*, and the Latin language.<sup>5</sup> This assertion helps us understand how little, in the first half of the twentieth century in Rome and in obedient English-speaking countries theology considered in a creative way the great themes of Christian revelation. Why would any progressive European theologian be discussed in the United States before and after World War II? The intellectual life of American Catholics, nourished by few journals and publishing houses, focused on the lives of saints or, for priests, upon rubrics and canon law. There were, of course, other directions in theology in northern Europe, but, in terms of the United States (French Canada had extensive contact with new European theologies), the lack of education among Catholics in general, the enclosure of theology in seminaries, and the monopoly of manual scholasticism in theology furthered the consideration of topics like the multiplicity of "esse" in Christ or the infused knowledge of Mary. This explains the ignorance or surprise which greeted the first appearances of other theologies after 1956: e.g., essays on the knowledge of Jesus, biblical studies, new approaches to religious education, and the first English translations of theologians like Edward Schillebeeckx and Karl Rahner.

A particular reason for ignoring Congar was his difficulties with the Vatican. By February of 1954 he had seen his publications like *Vraie et Fausse Reforme* curtailed or refused new editions, had been removed from his teaching position at *Le Saulchoir*, and had been sent into the first of several exiles. François Leprieur's *Quand Rome condamne* has described in detail what Paris' *Le Monde* called "the raid on the Dominicans."<sup>6</sup> Emmanuel Suarez, the Master General of the Order residing at Santa Sabina on the Aventine, the headquarters of the Dominicans, was sent a sweeping complaint from Cardinal Pizzardo. "You know well the new ideas and tendencies, not only exaggerated but even erroneous, which are developing in the realms of theology, canon law and society and which find a rather large resonance in certain Orders. . . . This deplorable state of affairs cannot help but preoccupy the Holy See when it considers that the religious orders are forces upon which the church can and must depend in a special way in its struggle against the enemies of truth." Pizzardo commanded Suarez to visitate the "*studia*," the seminaries of the Order, in France, to search out the suspicious ideas of teachers and students where "so-

called theologians with brilliant phrases and generalizations” were teaching falsehood.<sup>7</sup> There were rumors coming from the Vatican of closing the three provinces’ novitiates and seminaries. In February 1954 Suarez unexpectedly came to Paris to preside at a formal meeting with the provincial (of the province of Paris) and his council, the superiors of houses with priest workers, the director of studies for the young Dominicans at Le Saulchoir, and prominent theologians and teachers among which was Congar. The general indicated that the Vatican was accusing the Order of fostering in France a cluster of dangerous innovations. When pressed, the Vatican claimed that its complaints came from French bishops, but, the Dominicans protested, this was only partly true: some bishops were sympathetic and, after all, the French episcopate itself had begun new pastoral directions. Still, episcopal lack of support at crucial moments was the pattern, and Congar observed: “The bishops are completely boxed in by passivity and servility; if their devotion to Rome is sincere and filial, it is also childish, infantile.” Congar knew the Holy Office had many objections against his writings on ecumenism and reform in the church whose second editions had inevitably been blocked by Rome’s censorships. Along with others Congar would have to leave teaching, stop publishing, and submit any writings to prior Roman censorship. Congar, not known for a reluctance to speak his mind, exclaimed: “This is absurd! Simply inconceivable!”<sup>8</sup>

Meanwhile, two years later in the United States a curious article appeared in the *Saturday Evening Post*. “Adventures of the Freewheeling Priests”<sup>9</sup> reported on the “church’s most controversial order,” but the article could make no sense to American clergy and Dominicans. It described all Dominicans around the world as much the same and lumped together French priest-workers and ecumenists, American teachers who had no knowledge or sympathy with the progressive European Dominicans, and Roman administrators who presumed the French were trouble-makers; it linked the *École Biblique* in Jerusalem (then at work completing the *Bible de Jérusalem*) with schools in the United States whose theological life was exclusively a bland neo-Thomist philosophy.

## II. Entry in the 1960s

What made Congar known in the United States were his books, soon to be recognized as the books of an important theologian of the Council.

To look at Jean-Pierre Jossua’s bibliography for the dozen years before the Council is to find English translations for *Christ, Our Lady and the Church* (1952) in 1957, *Lay People in the Church* (1953) in 1957, for *After Nine Hundred Years* in 1959, for *The Mystery of the Temple* (1958) in 1962, for *Laity, Church and World* (1959) in 1960 and *Tradition and Traditions* (1960, 1963) in 1966. *The Mystery of the Church* (a joining of two books) appeared in the US in 1960 with a new perspective for ecclesiology (so different from the

seminary ecclesiologies of papal power) drawn from Incarnation and Pentecost and continued in the Pauline themes of Body of Christ and Holy Spirit at work in all Christians. *Wide World My Parish* from 1961 held pastoral essays, drawing from the new theological directions in France, inquiring into the nature and population of hell, freedom in moral acts, the end of the world and the resurrection, and Christianity and the world religions. (One might see similarities between this book's appearance and the publication in the United States in 1963 of the first volume of Karl Rahner's *Theological Investigations*, both introducing a post-scholastic, creative theology of the deepest principles of Christianity.) What is surprising is that in the 1950s Congar's casual writings on social issues like tolerance, Israel, conversion, Christian life in the world, and race were translated: one thereby might have gotten the impression that he was a social moral theologian rather than an ecclesiologist. Not to be overlooked is the absence of the scholarly work of the French Dominican: the broad surveys of publications in ecclesiology and ecumenism, the meticulous studies of medieval and patristic church forms, the essays on the nature of the church and of the theology of the church preparatory for the Council and for subsequent tomes.

Two books translated into English early, *Christ, Our Lady and the Church* and *Lay People in the Church*, probably had some particular influence. The first book appeared on the occasion of the fifteen centenary of the Council of Chalcedon. The context of this "study in eirenic theology" is complex: Congar himself has in mind both a Catholic audience and ecumenical partners who are Lutheran and Barthian, while the British translator, Henry St. John, situates the books in terms of Anglicanism. Did American readers get beyond this ecumenical discussion and see the ancient and new theology of the Incarnation present in Jesus, Mary, and the church? The triad participates differently in a similar interplay of the human and the divine, both eminently real and active in their own spheres. Greek theologians and Johann Adam Möhler offered their appreciation of the impact and extension of the incarnation. "Here then, it may be reiterated, is a meeting point upon which Our Lady and the church conclusively and positively converge; each represents the part that human instrumentality is given in the work of salvation through the Incarnation; the one brings it about, the other communicates it to men and permeates the world with its effects."<sup>10</sup> Although Congar understood that ecumenism must be drawn from traditional Protestant theologies and churches and not from the demythologizing methods of the universities, he was not sympathetic to the "Barthian insistence on the utter transcendence of God [obscuring] the reality of his self-communication."<sup>11</sup> The French theologian writing and lecturing among new movements drew the Chalcedonian theology into the realms of liturgy and of secular society awaiting and already touched by grace. He concluded by suggesting a new openness to Chalcedon for Protestants and a much richer appropriation of

its theology of the Incarnation for Catholics.

What did literate American Catholics, the few laity who had access to new ideas or worked in social and caritative movements, think of *Lay People in the Church*? There were progressive lay organizations like the Jocists, Catholic labor movements, the Catholic Rural Life Conference, and the Catholic Worker that were concerned with labor, peace and race, and for them it was certainly a foundation and a justification. As Congar came to see, the book was very much a product of the late 1940s, presenting theological and ministerial education in rather clerical ways and viewing ministry as monoform and hierarchical; the laity served largely as a bridge between church and society, and lay ministry was limited.<sup>12</sup> Nonetheless, it was a theological event because the laity lacked any active theological place in the church.

The American translation of Jean-Pierre Jossua's biography was of considerable importance.<sup>13</sup> It presented the purpose and scope of the theologian's remarkable efforts, placing him far above his critics and indicating his careful surveys of literature in ecclesiology and history. Certainly American ecclesiol-ogists like McBrien, Michael Fahey, Avery Dulles, Joseph Komonchak, and others have been influenced by Congar who spoke of the expansion of theology during his lifetime: "As someone reaching the age of 40 sees his son surpass him by both standing taller and receiving a better education, so the author of *Chrétiens désunis* sees himself exceeded on all sides by a numerous generation, magnificently gifted and generous."<sup>14</sup>

### III. The Legacy of Yves Congar

The books of a theologian are not always what perdure: during and after a lifetime of teaching or scholarship, it is not clear which writings and ideas will subsequently be of influence. Large writings from one decade may be forgotten or presumed later. What remains influential from Congar? M.-J. Le Guillou observed that Congar's theology was inevitably the result of pondering "the reality of the life of Christ in the church" and that his efforts led to a new "total-reflection" which joined hermeneutical questions with modern obstacles to faith, historical issues and expectations of new life in the church.<sup>15</sup> Congar's legacy certainly remains in the following four areas; (1) ecumenism, (2) the historicity of the church and the historical moment of Vatican II, (3) tradition understood as an organic ecclesial body reflecting on revelation, (4) the theology of the laity which has become an ecclesiology of diverse ministry.<sup>16</sup>

**Ecumenism.** One can suspect that Congar was first known in America as an ecumenist, although the ecumenical movement in the United States only assumed prominence in the 1960s. He had been a pioneer of the Catholic church's entry into ecumenism, West and East. "I became conscious of my ecumenical vocation inwardly in 1929 as I directed my work then to ecclesiology



(I chose in the summer of 1928 the unity of the church as thesis for the lecture). . . . Ordination to the priesthood approached: I was to receive it on the 25th of July 1930. I prepared myself by studying, on the one hand, the theology of the Eucharistic sacrifice. . . , and, on the other hand, Père Lagrange and St. Thomas on the Gospel according to John. As I meditated upon the seventeenth chapter of the Gospel of John, I received definitively the call to engage myself so that all who believed in Jesus Christ would be one.”<sup>17</sup> For Congar ecumenism was not an avocation or a high level dialogue about superficial differences but a meeting between Christians of different churches. To be ecumenical, contrary to early fears, meant not to lose one’s tradition and identity but to deepen it by complementing it from other Christian theologies. Church union would occur not with the surrender of the separated traditions but with and through their mutual understanding and cross-fertilization. The role of the Word of God, diverse perspectives on grace, the tension between church and society, a broader consideration of ministry, the personal dimension of the believer and of sin and the human condition — these he selected as Protestant emphases broadening Roman Catholicism.

Congar assisted in fashioning a new, more historical understanding of the Reformation along with a sympathetic comprehension of Luther in his age as reformer, theological genius, and mystic. Second he overcame the evaluation of Protestantism in Catholic apologetics since Trent. Third, church union was seen as eschatological, as a reality which was to be achieved now and in the future through work and mystery. “I have always conceived ecumenical work to take place first in one’s own house, in one’s own world. Since my interests, my vocation were theological, I saw ecumenism to be a theological work done by a theologian to assist the Catholic Church in moving from a vision of the church which was too juridical to a vision of the people of God proceeding under the active inspiration of the Trinity and then destined for the service of the world.”<sup>18</sup> Ecumenism was not a hobby but another name for the renewal of the churches.

In the 1960s the ecumenical movement had a sudden and considerable success in the United States as the country moved from being particularly prejudiced and anti-Catholic to developing various forms of contacts between Christians. Ecumenism in America was not only theological dialogue but pastoral renewal and education and cooperation among seminaries. That welcome and successful ecumenism, however, reached a plateau by 1980, and today ecumenism is presumed, has become static, and lacks vision. Perhaps in the United States the progress of the 1960s is as far as ecumenism can go for a while. The individual churches after 1970 turned, legitimately, to themselves: Catholicism faced challenges centering on the renewal of the local church, new biomedical issues, and the securing of Catholic identity in its growing population and expanding institutions. Mainline Protestantism faced ceaseless decline, as new

and fundamentalist churches multiplied. The ecumenical landscape of 1985 was utterly different from that of 1955 and 1965.

**The Historicity of the Church and a New Time.** Ecumenism, tradition, and church forms involve history. What is their historical context? Where did church forms come from and why did they change? Congar's personal vocation, chosen at the time of his ordination to the priesthood, was the renewal of the church through the renewal of ecclesiology, through a theology of the historical context of church forms. Neo-scholastic timelessness must yield to history. In everything the theologian-historian was always concerned to recover the sources, the roots.

Renewing the church in the twentieth century meant contemplating the forward, irrevocable movement of history. Eventually the church would leave behind the reduction of the Body of Christ to a juridical administration, leave behind the reduction of activity to the format of Pseudo-Dionysian and medieval hierarchies, leave behind the centralization made visual in Baroque architecture and intensified later in the administrative control of the Papi popes. After Trent for over three centuries the pendulum had moved in one direction, toward Roman centralism, toward one office whose language and conceptuality hid behind a melange of canon law, neo-scholasticism, and the bland religious language of the encyclical. Was it possible to pass beyond a church whose condition was that of a static monism and whose organization was a "hierarchology"?<sup>19</sup> To accomplish this there had to be something different, but not necessarily something utterly new. History and even the past itself would bring liberation.

The school of Le Saulchoir developed a critique of a theological and ecclesiastical era designated as the "Baroque." That word joined the properly Baroque time to its variation reaching from 1800 to 1960. That "system took in absolutely everything: theology, ethics, Christian behavior, religious practices, liturgy, organization, Roman centralization, the perpetual intervention of Roman congregations in the life of the church, and so on."<sup>20</sup> It was anti-Protestant in the style of the seventeenth century, anti-liberal in terms of the period after the French Revolution, neo-scholastic, and papalist. At the end of the section on the Counter-Reformation in *L'Église de saint Augustin à l'époque moderne*, Congar described the institutionalized ecclesiology which had lasted almost four centuries.

We can note the ecclesiological aspect of Roman centralization, which is, moreover, linked to a further important aspect. Trent had affirmed in the face of Protestantism that Christ is not solely a redeemer but that he is also a law-giver. In this line, even in its work at sustaining and demanding a kind of bishop who was truly pastoral, it favored the construction of a hierarchical order, but not one arranged around the Eucharist but around the 'regime' of which Rome occupies the center and summit. Despite the



admirable expansion of Christian life and pastoral ministry, an era of legalism began, replacing a somewhat theoretical ecclesiology. Finally an orthodoxy, not only of faith but of theology, is fixed by a kind of canonization of the conceptual and verbal system come down from scholasticism which from then to our own times has incorporated itself into Catholicism.<sup>21</sup>

Congar was convinced that the exciting decades of the French church from 1930 to 1960 were not simply suggesting selected reforms but opening a new era. Surprisingly and providentially Vatican II arrived and its newness consisted largely in its acceptance of the historicity of the church, scripture, and human culture.<sup>22</sup> “In leaving the Middle Ages and the Counter-Reformation we are leaving a legalism which has surrounded our ways of thinking since the end of the twelfth century. The consciousness of the church as it unfolds from the Council gives a primacy to the ontology of grace over the structures of law and authority which are in their place only as ministers at the service of a supernatural reality which is basically sacramental.”<sup>23</sup>

Congar’s journals from the years of Vatican II show a theologian calmly analyzing the underlying dynamic of the Council and the occasionally thin results of the conciliar documents. The church is resistant to change because it has more or less preferred a juridical structure in place since the ninth century. He writes of how the church is becoming again a church for people and not remaining with being an audience of passive believers. He values laypeople at the Council and is not afraid of their wider ministries; he sees the question of the ordination of women to be of central importance, and although he is not in favor of it, his reasons are drawn not from the incarnation but from his understanding of the ambiguous union of leadership and symbolism in women.<sup>24</sup> Jossua described in a recent encomium what the *peritus*’ conciliar journals show: “Congar in no way remained fixed within the advances or the limits of the Council. From the very first broad reception of Vatican II there was a lively openness to rapid changes in ideas and praxis.”<sup>25</sup> Congar mentioned in a later interview: “All the work of the Council is a half-way station.”<sup>26</sup>

A book of essays, *Le Concile de Vatican II*, is particularly valuable for seeing how he locates the event of the Council in past and future history. Whether in 1938 or 1978 Congar worked not just to research the past but to understand it, and then to employ the history of theologies and church institutions for the enabling of a future, more vital church. “The vision of the Council,” Congar wrote retrospectively, “has been resolutely that of the history of salvation completed by eschatology. . . . It is certain, or at least quite probable, that Vatican II will condition the life of the church for a long time. That council incorporated a great density of faithfulness and wisdom coming from the entire church: it is an event of a Pentecostal type.”<sup>27</sup> At the end of his history of ecclesiology from Augustine to the years following Vatican II, he observed that ideas such as the People of God, the expansion of the ministry, the church as the advocate of

humanity lead to a declericalized church, a church for the world. He thought too that the upheavals in the post-conciliar era had their roots not in Vatican II but in the constrictive decades and centuries before it. "The years after the Council are a global phenomenon with world-wide dimensions. A crisis would have come anyway. The Council assisted its entry into the church by ending the isolation of the church, by giving a wider audience to the church, and by ending a monolithic institution protected by fictions. The present time is linked to the gigantic change which touches culture, the ways of life in society and the 'cohumanity' around the world."<sup>28</sup> This is why, one could argue, history and not ecumenism or collegial episcopacy or lay ministry is the central dynamic of all of Congar's work.

**Tradition as the Organic Self-Reflection of the Church.** Congar advanced through his vocation of historical research a historical survey and a theology of tradition. He found tradition held captive in Catholicism by erroneous but widely held convictions: (1) tradition was static, timeless and yet claiming to be perennially complete; (2) it was located in patristic and papal documents; (3) it was a support for and an instrument of the papal magisterium. On the other hand, there was the prejudice that any movement away from finding tradition in documents would lead to the Protestant "*sola scriptura*", and that tradition would be absorbed in idealist philosophies and their offspring, Protestant histories of dogma distorting or diluting the content of revelation. A theology of tradition would show how tradition was not the same as the patristic writings (Migne), nor the ensemble of writings from patristic theologians, councils, and papal documents, (Denzinger), and also not the Roman magisterium.

Tradition was the life of the church underlying diverse realizations which served the communication of the Gospel apart from Scripture. "Tradition contains and preserves everything; it is the Gospel living in the church."<sup>29</sup> Like the church it progresses from interior presence to external expression, from the Spirit to its realized verbal and ecclesial forms, "a sort of progress from what was inside to what was outside, starting from the Spirit within which there is a constant striving to find an adequate expression."<sup>30</sup> Tradition finds support in the promise of the Spirit and the magisterium, but they exist to sustain the church in the upheavals of history and culture. "This tradition is *living* because it is not a *thing* exterior to living souls vivified by the Spirit".<sup>31</sup>

Tradition is the whole life of the church, dialectical and organic, sustaining a diversity of charisms and offices, perspectives and insights. The bearer and agent of tradition is not a past book or pope but an organically living collective self.

Through the Spirit, the truth taught by Jesus Christ is gradually assimilated more and more intimately and, through love, becomes the inspiration towards communion. The Spirit creates, from within, the unity of the community, and also the organs or expres-

sions of its special genius, i.e., its tradition. The heart of all these theological perspectives is the identity of the principle which acts throughout the Church's duration, and is at work in the activities by which it builds itself up, with that principle which was at work from the beginning in the revelation made to the prophets and the apostles, and in the saving actions of the incarnate Word.<sup>32</sup>

In a historically and sacramentally organic life the actions of the Body of Christ reflect on faith and ministry. This process is a spiritual "event" in each consciousness; Christians are not just witnesses to but bearers of tradition. "The whole ecclesial community is the organ of Tradition."<sup>33</sup>

**The Expanding Ministry.** Congar wrote in 1973: "People often ask me how I see the future of the church? It seems to me that it is necessary still to enlarge our viewpoints, [to see] that the church is called to become in a new way a church of all peoples, called to recognize in a new and more profound way its genius for expressing itself in great cultures. . . ."<sup>34</sup> A period of constraints is coming to an end, an expanding church has begun to leave a millennium-long Eurocentrism and to realize itself locally. History has led to local church, and local church immediately at the end of the Council led to ministry. "In every sphere, the church's potentialities are brought out by being actualized, and it is brought to self-understanding by events. That, after all, is the law of all living things."<sup>35</sup>

Since 1965 the ministerial life of the church has passed rapidly beyond a ministry found in the active forms of religious life largely from the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries and has re-entered the parish and diocese summoning through charism and education the baptized to enact the theology of ministry found in the Body of Christ. "The Church is an organic reality in which members receive a gift to enable them to fulfill a particular function."<sup>36</sup> Renewal of the church involves passing beyond the single ministry (bishop, priest, pope) which had absorbed everything. "The *responsibility* of witness and service flows from the Christian quality as such: thus there is mission in the broad sense, and this mission is equally incumbent on every Christian. All the disciples received the Holy Spirit and the gifts which render them responsible for God's cause."<sup>37</sup> Congar's seminal insights concerning universal activity in a church viewed as an organism are introduced in a general way: understandably he did not imagine in the 1950s or 1960s the expansion of ecclesial ministries which in fact occurred.

In 1953 Congar had written the first theology of the laity which began: "It is not just a matter of adding a paragraph or a chapter to an ecclesiological exposition which from beginning to end ignores the principles on which a 'laicology' really depends. Without these [new] principles we should have, confronting a laicised world, only a clerical Church which would not be the people of God in the fullness of its truth. At bottom there can only be one sound and sufficient theology of laity, and that is a 'total ecclesiology'."<sup>38</sup> Twenty years later, after

the Council, he reexamined that work and concluded: "I have not written that ecclesiology."<sup>39</sup> The decades since the Council have been occupied with parochial and diocesan diversity in ministries which have their source in the gifts of the Spirit to the Body of Christ. To these charismatically inspired public and ecclesial ministries some are ordained through baptism and others through further ordinations. Congar addressed anew in 1972 laity and ministry to correct a vision "which at first was principally and spontaneously clerical."

. . . The church of God is not built up solely by the actions of the official presbyteral ministry but by a multitude of diverse modes of service, more or less stable or occasional, more or less spontaneous or recognized, and, when the occasion arises consecrated, while falling short of sacramental ordination. These modes of service do exist . . . mothers at home, the person who coordinates liturgical celebrations or reads the sacred text, the woman visiting the sick or prisoners, adult catechists. . . They exist right now, but up to now were not called by their true name, ministries, nor were their place and status in ecclesiology recognized.<sup>40</sup>

This is very different from the church in the 1950s when a few thousand out of tens of millions shared in an ecclesially insignificant "apostolate" gingerly bestowed by bishops. That model changed. "It is worth noticing that the decisive coupling is not, 'priesthood/laity,' as I used it in *Jalons*, but rather 'ministries/modes of community service'."<sup>41</sup> The model replacing the bipolar division of clergy and laity is a circle with Christ and Spirit animating ministries in community. "It would then be necessary to substitute for the linear scheme a scheme where the community appears as the enveloping reality *within which* the ministries, eventually the instituted sacramental ministries, are placed as *modes of service* of what the community is called to be and do."<sup>42</sup> The venerable model of clergy and laity is fully incapable of explaining what the church has already become in many parts of the world. The people of God and the animating Spirit of the church are open to and restless for the rush of diversity in unity.

#### IV. Conclusion

What has been Congar's legacy in America? The four selected characteristics have certainly influenced the church in the United States. In a country of a largely Protestant background and pragmatic mentality, ecumenism and a theology of laity could only have great importance. Congar's high qualifications as a medieval historian and as a Dominican Thomist supported the end of neo-scholasticism which had held a monopoly in much of the church since the late nineteenth century. The past twenty years have witnessed a considerable number of discussions and conflicts over authority. Most of these have been

between the central authority and other entities, entities which the Council encouraged to claim some independent role: bishops' conferences, individual dioceses, bishops, theologians, lay and theological associations, regions of the church, and others. Opinions rejected by Congar as too mechanical, supernatural or shallow, theologies of the nineteenth century more often than of the Baroque, apparently are operating again within the Vatican. A mechanical centrism will always be in tension with an organic theology of the active Body of Christ. The challenge is to develop beyond the rather primitive ecclesiastical logic dominant from 1860 to 1960 to a sociology of shared knowledge, leadership, and communally held authority.<sup>43</sup> The identification of the contributors to the process of decision-making in the church and the description of their roles is fundamental as is the exploration of the process, neither monarchical nor democratic, by which each finds some power and voice.

Congar's understanding of the historicity of church forms still confounds fundamentalists who would choose a single age or devotion and identify that with Western Catholicism. Recently, restorationist voices, empty of any concrete pastoral or spiritual plans, reject Congar's appreciation of the historical context and momentous leap forward of Vatican II and his appreciation that the Baroque period must yield to something new. But the dynamic set in motion by the Council to enhance the local church as an organic community of charisms and ministries cannot be halted, and a theology of tradition as something of the present as well as of the past supports new directions in ecclesiology and ministry. In the face of exaggerated, autocratic practices in ecclesial teaching authority it is salutary to look anew at Congar's survey of the many theories of tradition, Spirit, and the sense of the faithful which have influenced the church in the past 150 years, some for good, some for ill, so as not to be drawn easily to a theory which is too centrist, too supernaturalist. Finally, in the expansion of the ministry, his own shift from a division of clergy and laity to circles of ministry grounded in the diverse presence of the Spirit is fundamental.

To re-read Congar is to be struck by his passion for history, a history which keeps the church alive but which from time to time sweeps some of its forms away. At the end of his journal for the last session of Vatican II he looked toward "L'Après-Concile." In a sense, he wrote, everything remains to be done. The church itself has not been questioned and the church's life is stronger. A new era has come: while some of the ecclesial bonds which held Catholics together will fade, nonetheless, this is necessary so that the mission of the church, going beyond vague phrases and curious devotions, can appreciate the world positively and bring into it the Gospel, expressing and pointing to the presence of grace. "What has been accomplished is fantastic. And nevertheless, everything remains to be done."<sup>44</sup>

## Notes

1. See the volume recently done for Germany: *Zäsur. Generationswechsel in der katholischen Theologie*, Gebhard Fürst, ed (Stuttgart: Akademie der Diözese Rottenburg-Stuttgart, 1997).
2. McBrien, "Church and Ministry: The Achievement of Yves Congar," *Theology Digest* 32 (1985), 203.
3. In a survey of *Theological Studies*, *The Thomist*, and *Homiletic and Pastoral Review* there is one article that devotes a page to Congar's theology (Sabbas J. Kilian, "Dialogue in Ecclesiology," *Theological Studies* 30 [1969], 61-78).
4. Review in *The Thomist* 21 (1958), 234; this journal had published in 1939 a translation of "The Idea of the Church in St. Thomas Aquinas" to appear twenty years later in *The Mystery of the Church*. In one of the few reviews Charles Henkey, a Dutch theologian at the University of Notre Dame, noted the role of continuing incarnational interplay of grace and person and indicated some affinity with Passaglia and Scheeben in the theology of grace and authority (review of *The Mystery of the Church* in *Theological Studies* 22 [1961] 487), while the knowledgeable Gustave Weigel reviewing in 1961 *After Nine Hundred Years* writes, "We have come to expect good things from Congar" (in *Theological Studies* 22 [1961] 309).
5. Dino Staffa, "L'Unità della fede l'unificazione dei popoli nel magistero del Sommo Pontefice Giovanni XIII," *Divinitas* 6 (1962): 3-32.
6. (Paris: Cerf, 1989), 41.
7. *Quand Rome condamne*, 41-45.
8. His difficulties were already fifteen years old at this time. "On the 27th of April, 1939, I was called to Paris at the same time as Fr. Chenu, my teacher and companion in work, by the Master General of the Order, Fr. M.- St. Gillet. He made me aware of certain difficulties, in themselves quite serious, raised by *Chrétiens désunis*, and even by the French translation of Möhler, *L'Unité dans l'Église* which appeared at the beginning of 1938 in *Unam Sanctam*. Upon my return I found six years of war and captivity waiting me. "(In captivity) I learned stupefied in the spring of 1942 that the Saulchoir was struck in the person of its inspiring director, Fr. Chenu (M.-D. Chenu, *Une École de théologie: Le Saulchoir* [Paris: Cerf, 1985]; a new edition with introductory-historical essays), "The meagre news which reached us in Silesia left us without any precision about the measures of which we knew neither breadth, the exact nature or the reasons" ("Le temps de la patience," *Une Passion: l'unité* [Paris: Cerf, 1974], 55-56). In 1950 Congar wrote of reactionary mindsets: "I do not believe that integrism is primarily a doctrinal position. . . it is fully a way of sensing and affirming Catholicism. It is primarily a mentality or an attitude determining a certain way of holding Catholic positions. . . . It is above all the nineteenth century which gave through two tendencies the occasion of forming clear attitudes; this was occasioned by problems posed by the Revolution. . . . One arrived at the point where among integrist Catholics and open Catholics there was a mutual contempt increased by paranoia. Catholic integrists having raised the bridges saw an enemy penetrating the castle, and they feared that others had made a pact with error and dabbled with heresy. On the other hand, open Catholics, formed by experiences which were not completely imaginary, suspected that the integrists were denouncing them in Rome. It is important to understand that . . . among integrists there was an enormous ignorance of history. . . . As the church is, by its structure, hierarchical and in its own form traditional, one understands that Catholics had often established a union between rightist attitudes and Catholic fidelity. It is this transposition which is the principle of integrism (which includes also) a certain way of conceiving 'the supernatural', 'the supernatural spirit,' and of fighting (under the name of 'naturalism') even healthy manifestations of human nature and subjectivity. A refusal of the modern world, a taste for all that is determined by the mode of authority comes basically from a contempt or a misunderstanding in regard to that which is presented as view of humanity, a development, and as emergence of new perspectives in history" (Congar, "Mentalité de droite' et l'intégrisme," *La vie intellectuelle* 22 [1950], 651, 654, 657).
9. Ernest O. Hauser, "Adventures of the Freewheeling Priests," *Saturday Evening Post* (January 9, 1956), 28-29, 100-102.
10. *Christ, Our Lady and the Church* (Westminster: Newman, 1957), 15.
11. *Ibid.*, 14. "Some expositions of our Lady's place show her too exclusively as endowed, in herself and on her own behalf, with unprecedented privileges; as if for instance God had willed in honouring man in Jesus Christ to honour woman in Mary. Some statements of ecclesiology perhaps treat the church too exclusively as an institution . . . [with an] independent power of disposal of God's gracious and continual bounty. This is certainly not the way Tradition and the Liturgy speak of it."
12. *Lay People in the Church* (Westminster: Newman, 1959), 297-298; see "The Laity," *Vatican II. An*



*Interfaith Appraisal* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1966), 239-249.

13. Yves Congar, *Theology in Service of God's People* (Chicago: Priory Press, 1968).

14. *Une Passion*, 8. The literature on Congar's thought is not extensive and would seem to consist mainly of published dissertations: Bishop Kenneth Untener, *The Church-World Relationship according to the Writings of Yves Congar, O.P.* (Rome: Pontificia Universitas Gregoriana, 1976); Timothy MacDonald, *The Ecclesiology of Yves Congar: Foundational Themes* (Lanham: University Press of America, 1984); Charles MacDonald, *Church and World in the Plan of God. Aspects of History and Eschatology in the Thought of Père Yves Congar* (Frankfurt: Lang, 1982); T. J. Lehning, "The Foundations, Functions, and Authority of the Magisterium in the Theology of Yves Congar" (Ph.D. diss. University of Notre Dame Université 1985); William Henn, *The Hierarchy of Truths according to Yves Congar, O.P.* (Rome: Pontificia Universitas Gregoriana, 1987); J. Famerée, *L'Écclésiologie de Yves Congar avant Vatican II* (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 1992).

15. Le Guillou, "Yves Congar," in *Bilanz der Theologie im 20. Jahrhundert. Bahnbrechende Theologen*, ed. Herbert Vorgrimler and Robert Vander Gucht (Freiburg: Herder, 1970), 189, 198.

16. Timothy MacDonald selects as "foundational themes" structure and life, reform within the tradition, church and laity, church and world, church as communion (*Church and World in the Plan of God*. . .). "To the extent there is a 'Congarian theology,' it would be a theology that would have united exposition to knowledge of the sources. I am not a philosopher. I lack philosophical training and a philosophical spirit; so I have not produced a theology like that of Karl Rahner, speculatively elaborated" ("Letter from Father Yves Congar, O.P.," *Theology Digest* 32:3 [Fall, 1985], 215); see the entertaining congratulations from Congar to Rahner written as a letter from Thomas Aquinas: "Die Offenheit lieben gegenüber jeglicher Wahrheit. Brief des Thomas von Aquino an Karl Rahner," *Mut zur Tugend* (Freiburg: Herder, 1979), 124-133.

17. "Preface. The Call and the Quest," *Dialogue between Christians* (Westminster: Newman, 1966), 1-51. Congar never ceased to acknowledge with gratitude his schooling in Thomas Aquinas and the fact that he had been educated by M.-D. Chenu in the new approach of the Dominican's Le Saulchoir (their provincial studium south of Paris). That particular style of approaching Aquinas (in contrast to various perennial neo-Thomisms) was historical and textual, locating Aquinas and other theologians in their historical context. Le Saulchoir appreciated anew the dynamic element in Aquinas' writings (largely muted by static neo-scholasticism) (See J.-P. Torrell, "Yves Congar et l'écclésiologie de Saint Thomas d'Aquin," *Revue des sciences philosophiques et théologiques* 82 [1998], 201-242).

18. Congar, "Remarks on the Occasion of Receiving the Watson Prize for Ecumenism," *Ut unum sint*, Newsletter of the Dominicans of the Province of Paris (December, 1984).

19. "Not a hierarchy" *Jalons pour une théologie du laïc* (Paris: Cerf, 1953), 68f.; "Not a hierarchy," Congar, *Ministères et communion ecclésiale* (Paris: Cerf, 1971), 10. "The term, 'hierarchy' which I introduced in 1947 has since then been taken up a little widely." Congar, "Situation . . . au moment," 13. Congar described at some length his views on another theology of the Body of Christ, *Mystici Corporis* of Pius XII. Appreciative of its efforts to offer some new directions, the letter remains too ordered to the papacy and hierarchy and not to the full body of Christ; it is unrelated to Pauline exegesis, too captive to illustrating the members of the body in terms of interior spiritual life and receiving the sacraments (*L'Église de saint Augustin*, 470ff.).

20. Congar, *Fifty Years of Catholic Theology: Conversations with Yves Congar*, B. Lauret, ed. (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1988), 3f.; see Congar, "Les théologiens, Vatican II et la théologie," *Le Concile de Vatican II*, 81. That ecclesiastical format Congar also called a Bellarminian juridicism: "Bellarmine (*Ecclesia est coetus hominum ita visibilis et palpabilis*. . .) is dominated by the need to be able to precise the church of Christ as well as to be able to say who is and who is not a member of the church. . . . In short, he deliberately pictures the church, even under its title of the Body of Christ, from the perspective of external elements, from the visible and externally verifiable." 'Lumen Gentium No. 7,' 'L'Église,' *Corps mystique du Christ*, vu au terme des huit siècles d'histoire de la théologie du Corps mystique," *Le Concile de Vatican II* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1984), 147-151.

21. *L'Église de saint Augustin* 368. Congar here as elsewhere cited Johann Adam Möhler's saying: "God created the hierarchy and thereby had provided more than enough for the needs of the church until the end of the world." That ecclesiology was typified in manuals like a text by Gerard Paris, widely used in the *studia* of Dominican Order: the *Tractatus de ecclesia Christi ad mentem S. Thomae Aquinatis* (Malta: Muscat, 1949) presented the four causes of the church in Aristotelian language: the formal cause was the bishops;

the efficient cause was Jesus, the Holy Spirit, and the bishops; the final cause was heaven; the material cause, like clay for a statue, was everyone who was not a bishop, provincial, or pastor.

22. *Fifty Years of Catholic Theology: Conversations with Yves Congar* 8.

23. "L'Avenir de l'église" (1964), *Écrits Réformateurs* (Paris: Cerf, 1995) 367.

24. See *Le Concile au jour le jour* (Paris: Cerf, 1963-1966); the observations on the ordination of women are from the journal of the third session, pp. 93ff.

25. Jossua, "Yves Congar. La vie et l'oeuvre d'un théologien," *Cristianesimo nella storia* 17 (1996), 9.

26. J. Puyo, *Une vie pour la vérité. Jean Puvo interroge le Père Congar* (Paris: Le Centurion, 1975) 149.

27. "Situation ecclésiologique au moment de 'Ecclesiam suam' et passage à une église dans l'itinéraire des hommes," *Le Concile de Vatican II*, 27.

28. *Une passion* 109; Congar wrote: "I do not believe that the present crisis in the church is the result of Vatican II . . . the realities that preoccupy us today were already present or beginning to appear in the 1950s and even in the 1930s." Congar, "A Last Look at the Church," in Alberic Stacpoole, *Vatican II Revisited* (Minneapolis: Winston, 1986) 351.

29. Congar, *Tradition and Traditions* 193.

30. *Ibid.* 193f.

31. *Ibid.* 193f.

32. *Ibid.* 340.

33. *Ibid.* 324.

34. *Une Passion* 112; see Untener, *The Church-World Relationship according to the Writings of Yves Congar, O.P.*

35. "The Life of the Church and Awareness of its Catholicity," *The Mystery of the Church* (Baltimore: Helicon, 1965) [2nd edition], 100.

36. *Tradition and Traditions* 321.

37. Congar, *Le Concile au jour le jour* Session IV (Paris: Cerf, 1966) 61; see *Tradition and Traditions*, 329- 341.

38. *Lay People in the Church*, xvi.

39. Congar, "My Path-Findings, 169.

40. Congar, "My Path-Findings, 181. He spoke of the basic equality of the baptized and of a diversity of services and offices which involves some inequality (at times he put "laity" in quotation marks). "Vision de l'élise comme peuple de Dieu," *Le Concile de Vatican II*, 114.

41. Congar, "My Path-Findings 176.

42. Congar, "My Path-Findings 178.

43. See Richard Gaillardetz, *Witnesses to the faith. Community, Infallibility, and the Ordinary Magisterium of the Church* (Mahwah: Paulist Press, 1991); *Teaching with Authority. A Theology of the Magisterium* (Collegeville: Liturgical Press, 1997).

44. *Le Concile au jour le jour. Quatrième Session* (Paris: Cerf, 1966) 151-152.